

A Short Guide to Cheese

by The CSE Cheese Society. Last updated January 2026.

Cheese is one of humanity's oldest prepared foods. People have made it for at least 7,000 years, long before written history. At its core, cheese is simple: milk, salt, cultures, and rennet. Time and technique do the rest.

What Is Cheese, Really?

Cheese begins when milk separates into curds and whey. The curds are pressed, salted, and aged. Every variable matters: the animal, the season, the cave, the patience of the maker. Change one and you get a different cheese. This is why a single recipe has produced thousands of distinct varieties.

The word "cheese" comes from the Latin **caseus**, which also gives us the word "casein," the main milk protein.

Famous Families of Cheese

Fresh

Young and mild: mozzarella, ricotta, and chèvre. Eat these within days.

Soft-ripened

These grow a white bloomy rind. Brie and Camembert are the classic examples. The rind is edible and you should eat it.

Blue

Veined with ***Penicillium roqueforti***. Roquefort, Gorgonzola, and Stilton lead this family. They are salty, sharp, and divisive.

Hard

Aged for months or years. Parmigiano-Reggiano, aged Gouda, and Comté reward the wait with crystals of crunch and deep, nutty flavor.

A Word of Caution

The American product known as "processed cheese food" is, at best, distantly related to cheese. Read the label.

"Cheese is milk's leap toward immortality.

— attributed to Clifford Budman

Try It Yourself

Which of these have you tasted?

☐ Brie

☐ Roquefort

☐ Aged Gouda

Tell us your favorite cheese:

e.g. Comté

Add it to the guide